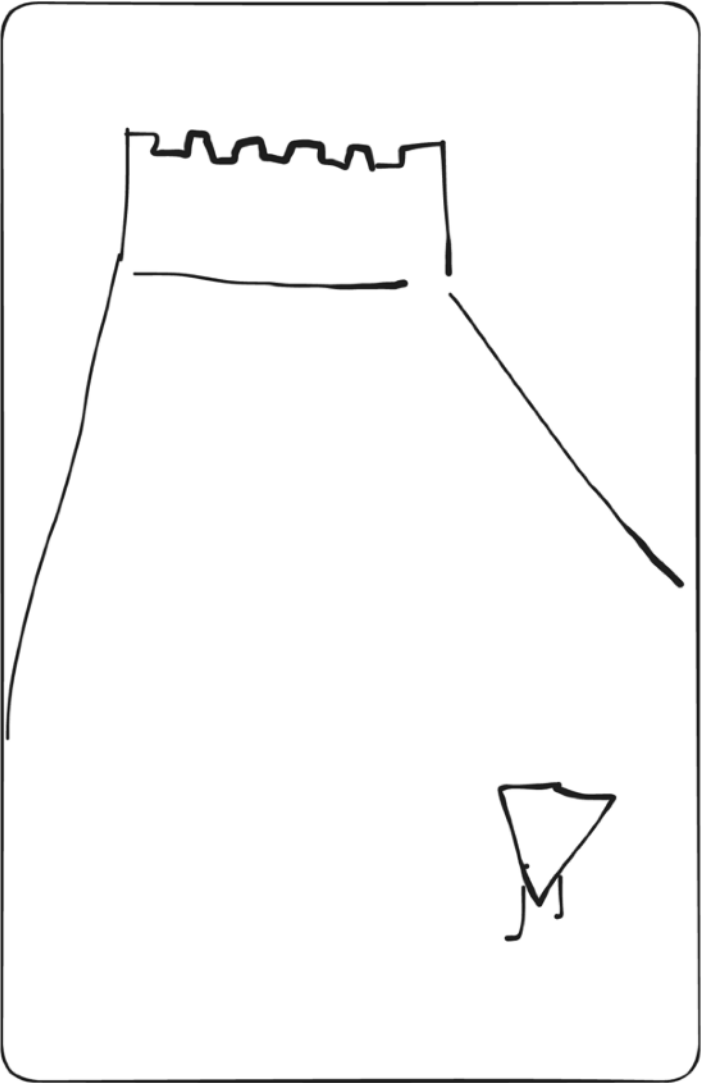


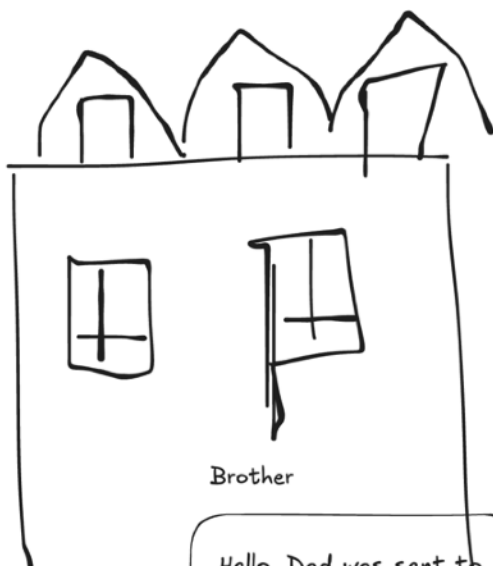
EMPOWERING AGEING

LONG-TERM HEALTH IS IN EACH
PERSON'S HANDS AND IT'S
THRILLING!



I started this book thinking a lot about my parents' and my children's health during my Edinburgh inner journey.

Don't spend all your life reading books about how to live it.
Even this one.



Brother

Hello, Dad was sent to
the hospital in emergency



Sister

Hello, Mum is not very well
since their examination

INTRODUCTION

PERSONAL DECLINE?

The only three absolute convictions in life remain: I was born, I will die, and between in, I live.

Someone forgot to design the human body for eternity. Indeed, our bodies start to decline in our late teens. For someone living until the age of a hundred, that is a very long time to spend with a declining body!

The long decline comes in silence, until the day we can no longer live on our own. Of course, nobody wants to lose their independence. Nobody wants to rely on others just to stay alive.

So the way we face our declining bodies seems to be a truly personal topic.

But there is a fly in is ointment, no matter what our personal vision of decline is, if we become dependent it involves many people around us.

According to the United Nations, by 2050, one in four people on the planet will be over 60. One in three people in Western countries.

The bad news is that the overall health of people over 60 is not good. ¹ And now, the very bad news: their total number is growing fast.

So the more people over 60 there will be, the more people to take care of them we will need and the more financial resources we will dedicate.

Indeed, younger generations will have lower incomes, lower living conditions, less time for themselves and even poorer health!

Personal decline is definitely not only a personal issue, it is a social question.

And if the situation goes on, personal decline will turn into social decline.

To rewrite the future, our societies need a dramatic health improvement for the over 60s.

That is this book's purpose: to age well and help others do the same.

That said, that's where the problems start.

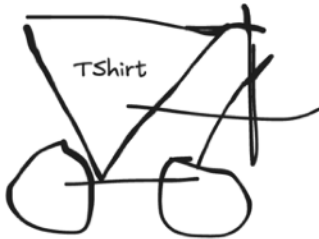
¹ World health statistics 2025 / <https://iris.who.int/server/api/core/bitstreams/c992fbdc-11ef-43db-a478-7e7a195403ae/content>

Ageing well is a very complex challenge at the crossroads of virtually every academic discipline: genetics, biology, physiology, nutrition, psychology, neurology, physics, economics, sociology and even theology and philosophy.

A challenge harder to solve than an equation with ten unknowns.

This book wants to turn it into something simple and spicy!

5° Strong wind



Scottish people seem to
have strong genes!



PART ONE

RECODING THE PROBLEM

CHAPTER ONE

IS OUR DECLINE A SENTENCE?

Bad news: the answer is YES.

Good news: a sentence can be rewritten.

We know that only the gods of antiquity lived for eternity. We humans are made mortal. We are not eternal because our bodies stop growing in our twenties.

DNA and genes, two of the most miraculous things in the Universe, tell the body when to grow and when to decline. More precisely decline means that genes are less and less efficient at repairing the body year after year.

Our genes decide when our bodies stop functioning. We can't live beyond our genetic limits.

Nevertheless we don't know how long human genes could really maintain a body alive.

At the dawn of humanity, our hunters-gatherers ancestors probably had a life expectancy around 30 years. Yet, despite we still carry the same stone age genes, the global average life expectancy is now above 70 years.

But lifespan has increased just since the 1800s, not gradually over 200,000 years.

In just 200 years, the world has changed enough to double the life expectancy!

That sounds great - but, the quest for a longer lifespan is a trap.

First, because there is no guarantee that life expectancy will increase and even remain stable in the future. With population decline in developed countries, there will be fewer scientists, doctors, nurses, caring younger generations and less health care to maintain life expectancy at the current level.

And second, because even if one day the global average lifespan is one hundred years, we would still spend too much time in poor health or in dependency.

The real issue is: our bodies decline too early and we are not able to keep them functioning until the end.

Our life experience confirms the figures. Although, we all know some people who lived a long life without dependency - just a very fast decline before they went, we also know more people who face more and more health issues after their 60s and often before.

Moreover, epigenetics teaches us that average lifespan says nothing about our genes' full potential – and everything about how our genes react to our environment and lifestyle.

The same person's genes react completely differently depending on whether they breathe pure air or not, drink alcohol or not, eat ultra-processed food or not, exercise or not.

In other words – average lifespan reveals the potential of genes living in the average environment, with the average lifestyle, of a specific era.

Here is a new challenge: could we truly beat the average environment and the average lifestyle?

If you spend too much time commuting, could you move house to be closer to work?

If your job is too stressful, could you change it?

If you drink too much alcohol, could you keep partying with your family and mates while drinking only smoothies?

And so on.

Generally speaking, social status, time availability, financial resources and environment are largely beyond any individual's control.

Your social status shape your diet. Your time availability shape your physical activity. Your financial resources shape where you live. Your environment shape the air you breathe.

Here is the final challenge to answer this chapter's question: to rewrite your decline sentence, you have to find which changes are truly in your hands. Self-honesty leads to effectiveness.

By escaping the average lifestyle, you will avoid the average sentence.

And remember: stop thinking in lifespan terms and start reasoning in healthspan logic.

Think ageing well

If you make that decision today, consider yourself a new kind of Socrates, Marie Curie or Gandhi!

By becoming that champion of inner transformation you will be able to use your wonderful genes until their full potential.

Game pause #1

Who lived the longest in full activity?
Socrates, Marie Curie or Gandhi

Answer page #

Let's have a short pause.

What do we know up to now?

First: we can't live beyond our genetics limits -> Philosophy and theology have studied a lot that question extensively.

Second: we can't predict the full potential of our genes -> Genetics is making great progress on that topic, one day it could give the answer.

Third: Our genes react to our environment and lifestyle -> Epigenetics proved it and is also making great progress to know why and how some of our genes are switched on or off.

Fourth: We can't easily change our environment and lifestyle -> Economics and sociology have worked on that question and try to bring solutions for a political action.

Fifth: We do not have a degree in each of these disciplines.

Sixth: We are not politician and we are not responsible for the nation's health, only our own.

So what can we do with that mess?

Hand draw

CHAPTER TWO

GENES, MARKERS AND PILLARS

It's time to try to make things simpler.

What does « ageing well » mean?

I have synthesised books, articles, studies and podcasts about healthy longevity to learn that we age well when, over 60 years, we navigate ageing without physical, psychological and cognitive problems.

In other words « ageing well » means « physical, psychological and cognitive wellness ».

The full potential of our physical, psychological and cognitive functions depends on our genes.

The full potential of our genes depends on their sensibility to inputs. That process is called « DNA methylation ».

The DNA methylation depends on lifestyle and environment inputs.

Our environment depends on where we live and lifestyle depends on our habits.

Here is a large part of the foundation of aging well: our habits.

Let's capture it all in a sketch.

Physical wellness
(Output)

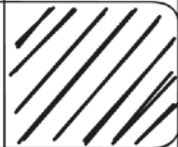
Psychological
wellness
(Output)

Cognitive wellness
(Output)

Ageing well

Genes

DNA Methylation



Lifestyle

Physical
habits
(Inputs)

Psychological
habits
(Inputs)

Cognitive
habits
(Inputs)

Environment

Looking at the sketch we realise the large role of environment. It impacts our long-term health both directly and indirectly.

Environment is a factor for DNA methylation, so for example, a bad environment could activate bad genes and switch off good genes. In this case, it indirectly damages the long-term health.

Environment has also a direct impact on the long-term health. For example, even with the best genes and lifestyle, someone living in a toxic area (air, soil and water contaminated) will probably suffer poor health.

So to keep things simple, let's consider that we can't change the environment because it is the result of millions of years of climate evolution or hundreds of years of human activities. The only option is to change our location for a better environment. But that makes sense only for a very few people indeed.

So, even if it is highly difficult, our lifestyle habits remain the only things we can change.

As explained at the start of this chapter, physical, psychological and cognitive topics are at the top and at the base of the sketch because we need to make a clear distinction between outputs and inputs: results are not the causes.

In other words, to see a change at the top of this sketch find the key in the base :-)

Here are the three core pillars of ageing well!

The physical, psychological and cognitive habits.

There are only three, and once they become legendary, they will be nicest and easier to remember than the four horsemen of the Apocalypse, don't you think ?

Every repeated physical activity, sport, drink, air, food, drugs that we put into our body is a physical habit.

Every repeated activity that influences our self-esteem, inner-peace and outer connection is a psychological habit.

Every repeated activity that influences our memory, processing ability and creativity, is a cognitive habit.

Of course, to become the pillars of our ageing well our habits have to be healthy habits. We will see in part three what healthy habits are, but I suspect you already know.

Yet being a healthy habit is not enough.

A habit's quality depends on mindfulness, balance and a real-life-proven schedule.

Physical
habits

(Inputs)

Psychological
habits

(Inputs)

Cognitive
habits

(Inputs)

Mindful

Balance

Real-life-proven schedule

Let's study this second sketch:

The more mindful we are when practising a healthy habit, the bigger positive impact we create on our long-term health.

For example:

A quiet slow healthy lunch, rather than a quick healthy lunch scrolling on our telephone.

A physical exercise with deep focus, rather than with music playing.

Consciously tracking our psychological or a cognitive exercise.

Great, but mindfully habits alone are not enough.

For example: someone who spends 4 hours per day only doing sport remains exposed to psychological and cognitive issues. Sport alone doesn't protect psychological health, world champions in burnout prove it!

And of course, it will be the same for someone who spends many hours per day strengthening cognition with strategic games, memory exercises and mental arithmetic without any wellness and sport activity.

So we absolutely need to balance our habits across all three pillars.

Finally, we practise well-balanced, high-quality healthy habits, there is only one thing missing: can they survive in our overwhelming schedule?

Well-balanced, high-quality healthy habits need a real-life-proven schedule.

For example:

A mother of three young children practises a 30 minute habit three times a week.

A retiree practices the same habits three times a day.

Same habits. Different schedules. Both real-life-proven.

CHAPTER THREE

HOW STRONG IS YOUR AGEING WELL
HABITS STRUCTURE?

In this chapter, we'll talking about our personal habits, not about our current health. We're focusing on the long term.

We want to understand whether our habits give us the best chance of staying healthy as we get older.

All our habits together form a personal habit structure.

So let's see if that structure is strong enough - Let's doing a habit structure audit.

You can do your audit online or using the following questionnaire.

The questionnaire is divided into seven sections. For every question, collect one point for the first answer, two for the second, three for the third and four for the fourth.

Answer honestly, there are no right or wrong answers, only your truth.

Section A

PHYSICAL STRENGTHENING INPUTS

1) Do you engage with light physical activity?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

2) Do you practice a cardio activity?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

3) Do you practice a strength activity?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

4) Do you practice a mobility activity?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

5) Do you practice a balance activity?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

6) Do you practice a proprioception activity?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

7) Do you practice stretching exercises?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

8) Do you practice breathing exercises?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

9) Do you drink alcohol?

- Every day
- A few times a week
- A few times a month
- Never

10) Do you consume tobacco?

- Every day
- A few times a week
- A few times a month
- Never

11) Do you consume drugs?

- Every day
- A few times a week
- A few times a month
- Never

12) Do you consume sugar?

- Every day
- A few times a week
- A few times a month
- Never

13) Do you consume processed food?

- Every day
- A few times a week
- A few times a month
- Never

Section B

PSYCHOLOGICAL STRENGTHENING INPUTS

1) Do you read books, listen to programmes or study materials about self-esteem?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

2) Do you practice self-esteem strengthening exercises?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

3) Do you read books, listen to programmes or study materials about inner peace?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

4) Do you practice inner peace strengthening exercises?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

5) Do you read books, listen to programmes or study materials about meditation?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

6) Do you practice meditation exercises?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

7) Do you read books, listen to programmes or study materials about empowerment?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

8) Do you track your empowerment capacity?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

9) Do you read books, listen to programmes or study materials about focusing?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

10) Do you practice focusing strengthening exercises?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

11) Do you read books, listen to programmes or study materials about human connection?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

12) Do you track your human connection capacity?

- Never
- A few times a month
- A few times a week
- Every day

13) Do you spend time on social media?

- Every hour
- A few times a day
- A few times a week
- Never

Section C

COGNITIVE STRENGTHENING INPUTS

How can we improve our habit structure?

CHAPTER FOUR

IDENTIFY THE BARRIERS

If we truly want to improve our habit structure, we can first identify all the barriers that could stop us from building new habits.

Nobody will face all the barriers at once, but knowing them all will help enormously in any case.

There are ten barriers.

1) No immediate reward

In my opinion this is the main barrier and everyone faces it.

It could be described like this: why spend time every day to practice a habit that eventually could improve my health in twenty years?

Or, why give up a bad habit that gives immediate pleasure for a benefit I may not see for years?

Even, worst: why do I have bad habits despite my healthy intentions?²

I remember a friend who telling me « I like running, because I fell good after a session. But, to be honest I have no time to do a memorisation exercise that might only help

² Does temporal discounting explain unhealthy behavior? / 2014 / <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC3950931/>

me in thirty years ». This is a perfect example of the importance of immediate reward.

2) A too complex subject

We know that the human body is not designed to last forever, but we don't really know why. We can't fully explain why our cells gradually stop functioning properly, or why their ability to repair themselves declines year after year.

The best scientists and the richest companies have been searching for answers, yet there has been no real breakthrough so far.

A study led by several European universities and research institutes³ argues that ageing is not caused by a single process but by a network of interconnected mechanisms that reinforce each other. Effective interventions tend to target multiple pathways at once rather than a single cause.

The study proposes twelve hallmarks of ageing: genomic instability, telomere attrition, epigenetic alterations, loss of proteostasis, disabled macroautophagy, deregulated

³ Hallmarks of ageing: an expanding universe / 2023 / [https://www.cell.com/cell/fulltext/S0092-8674\(22\)01377-0](https://www.cell.com/cell/fulltext/S0092-8674(22)01377-0)

nutrient sensing, mitochondrial dysfunction, cellular senescence, stem cell exhaustion, altered intercellular communication, chronic inflammation, and dysbiosis.

Did you count them all? Did you understand them all?

If you're not a scientist, certainly not!

So it is tempting to say: "the problem is so complex, how can I change anything about it. Let's give up!" - isn't it ?

3) Time illusion

Human body starts to decline in our late teens. The good news is that decline is gradual, so fortunately we are not yet disabled at 25. However, the bad news is that we tend to think we have our whole lives ahead to build habits for healthy ageing.

The phenomenon is called 'temporal discounting'⁴. We tend to choose small immediate rewards over large future ones and we tend to prefer large future risks to small present efforts.

⁴ Temporal discounting and health behavior: a review / 2017 / <https://medcraveonline.com/MOJPH/temporal-discounting-and-health-behavior-a-review.html>

Indeed our personal time perception significantly affects the quality of our habit structure.

4) Intention-action gap

We face this barrier when we are unable to correctly estimate the overall cost of an action.

Having an intention costs little: we spend only a small amount of time expressing it. In contrast, taking action requires significant time, energy, psychological, cognitive and financial resources. Sometimes, the greatest cost is only giving up an immediate reward.

We all experienced this phenomenon at the beginning of the year: we commit too many things without considering how we will achieve them.

The intention-action gap can lead to self-esteem issues when people make public commitments publicly but fail to follow through.

5) Daily urgency always wins

How can we think long term when we are overwhelmed by daily urgencies?

Modern life, with more free time, information, advertising, financial resources, and technology creates the illusion that we can live a hundred lives in one.

So we try to do as much as possible: we are a person, a life-partner, a worker, a parent, a son or a daughter, a friend, an athlete, an artist, a voyager, a citizen, a life-long learner - all at once.

But the more different activities we take on, the more daily urgencies we create. In this sense, modern life is largely incompatible with long-term action.

6) No personalised guidance

Personalised guidance in building healthy habits means tailored offers, advices and support designed specifically for an individual.

Each people has their own preferences in life. So when someone starts to build an healthy habit, they have to find an habit made for them.

This is a frailty step, because the range of habits is too large or because several habit choices didn't match.

Building habits is hard when habits are not personalised.

7) No trusted guide

Ageing well is a topic at the crossroads of so many academic disciplines and issues that a huge variety of people are involved.

Doctors, scientists, economists, politicians, caregivers, workout coaches, journalists, lifestyle influencers and

philosophers have all produced enormous amounts of content on the subject.

If we type « ageing well » into the search engine of an online bookstore, we'll find over 1,600 different books as a result.

Indeed, choosing a trusted guide is a big deal.

Once again, the overchoice could lead to inaction.

8) No community

Whatever your goal, community is key to perform. A community brings inspiration, teaching, motivation and support. Unfortunately, I have never heard about a club of ageing well! In my opinion, that kind of club or community will never exist because that subject is too large.

But it doesn't matter because, we can find as many communities we want for each pillar of ageing well. We can join a running club for the physical strengthening, a chess club for the cognitive strengthening and a volunteer group for the psychological strengthening.

Finally, finding communities is not a real difficulty.

The real barrier is... the whole community, our society.

In our modern society, we work, we commute, we care children or relatives, we have no time to practice sport, ultra processed food are everywhere, we spend most of time sitting (in the car, in the tube, at work, eating, watching tv, scrolling, and so on),

Our whole community will not properly support our ageing well choice.

9) Invisible enemy

If we smoke the enemy is the cigarette, If we drink: the wine bottle, if we eat badly: the fast food, if we are sedentary: the joint pain. But if our lifestyle doesn't care about aging well, where is the enemy? What is it?

We can't see the enemy, because yet it doesn't exist.

So, what should we do to face a trouble we don't identify? What is the right option?

10) Overwhelmed of perfection

It's well known barrier in lot of topics. When we start something new (building a new healthy habit for instance) it's always hard at the beginning. We have to make place for the new activity and we have to learn something new.

If the change seems to difficult, we tend to give up because we don't master enough the new habit.

11) Social media bad influence

--

At first glance, the conclusion of this chapter might seem to be the following: there are so many barriers that doing the right thing feels impossible.

But we can also look at the problem differently.

Yes, getting started is difficult. The good news, however, is that once we overcome those barriers and initiate movement, we have already done the hardest part.

CHAPTER FIVE

FOUR KEYS TO START

Naturally, as individuals, we are not concerned with all barriers.

Anyway, no matter how many barriers we face, if we use these four simple keys, we can start easily.

Now, how to start building habits for ageing well?

The importance of habit is an ancient idea: in *Nicomachean Ethics*, book II, Aristotle argues that a moral character comes from habits ⁵.

Nevertheless, the scientific study of habit is modern. In the 20th century, behaviourism studied habit formation through stimulus and reward and became famous.

In the 21st century, habits became part of mainstream culture. A book called 'Atomic habits' by James Clear reached millions of readers⁶. In my opinion, this book will be a reference for a long time for anyone who wants to start building good personal habits.

For those who don't have time to read this book - or those who don't want to be expert in building habits - this

⁵ Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, Book II, Chapter 1 (1103a-1103b)

⁶ <https://jamesclear.com/books>

chapter shows how to easily start to build habits for ageing well.

First key : make it small

In his book, James Clear suggests to always start building a new habit with an easy task. 'The version of the habit must be so easy that you can't say no to doing it'.⁷

Small habits are powerful because they are easy to start and likely to last.

If we choose a habit to build, we need to work on it before starting. It has to be so small, that it feels almost too easy.

Here is an example for each core pillar.

If I am not a consistent runner, it is useless - and dangerous - to commit to running ten kilometres per day from now on. Instead, I could plan to run 5 kilometres every week.

If I struggle with my memory, it is useless to commit to memorising twenty new words in the dictionary every day. Instead, I could plan to memorise one new word per day.

⁷ <https://jamesclear.com/small-habits>

Things are a little different with habits concerning the psychological function. In that field, habits are already generally small. For example, spending five minutes each morning to write a gratitude journal is already small and easy. In fact, I can start strengthening my psychological state with one small habit per day.

Second key : make it attractive

Once we have made the habit easy to do, we have to create a desire for it. The habit should become so desirable, that we never forget to do it.

Ageing well habits produce long-term outcome - so to make them attractive right now, we need to feel that the immediate experience is rewarding.

This mechanism is called reward association or temptation bundling.⁸

Here are some examples of immediate rewards linked to the new small habits:

- Listen to a favourite song only before a sport session.
- Drink a favourite beverage only after a sport session.

⁸ Teaching temptation bundling to boost exercise / <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S074959782030385X>

- Eat a favourite home-made cake only to start a cognitive training.
- Watch a favourite series episode only after a cognitive training.
- Use a very beautiful pen only to write a gratitude journal.
- Light a scented candle only for the evening routine.

Third key: progress step by step

A habit is something we do repeatedly over the long-term - so we need to avoid difficulty. We have to ensure that we can easily repeat each habit for a long time.

In other words, we should not rush to build more difficult habits, we should let success beget success.

We need to be slow and progressive - and with time we could build more and more new habits.

Fourth key: start with a balance across the three core pillars

This fourth key could be called a 'meta-habit'.

We all have different preferences in life. Some like running, others enjoy playing strategy games and others prefer spending time meditating. Naturally, we tend to build habits linked to our personal inclinations.

However, we have to remember that ageing well means age without physical, cognitive and psychological pain, so from the very beginning we should build the habit of balancing our habits.

If not, we would not leave enough room in our schedule for the three kinds of habits - and we would lose precious years of habit compounding.

Why these four keys will work ?

The European Journal of Preventive Cardiology published a study involving more than 500,000 people over ten years. The study showed that a minimum between-individual increase of approximately 10 minutes per day of sleep, 5 minutes per day of moderate to vigorous activity, and 3 DQS points -equivalent to one-fourth of a cup of vegetables per day - was associated with a 10% lower risk of major adverse cardiovascular events - heart attack, stroke and cardiovascular death.⁹

⁹Combined variations in sleep, physical activity, and nutrition and the risk of major adverse cardiovascular events / <https://doi.org/10.1093/eurjpc/zwag141>

That is scientific proof that small healthy habits can dramatically improve health over the long term.

CHAPTER SIX

MORE MOTIVATION TO START AND LAST

The earlier we start, the easier it gets.

We saw that daily urgency always win. As a result, we think that it's never the good moment to start building a habit. But, one thing is certain: if it's not the good moment right now, it will be the same next month and in ten years.

So if difficulty is always here. I should to act right now. I will have more time to chose a habit that fit me.

Moreover, over the years bad habits will capture my energy. If I tell to myself that I need to give up a bad habit in the future: it's procrastination, and research suggests that postponing a task may create a persistent cognitive and emotional load that can consume more mental energy than completing the task immediately.

Definitely it is easier to start soon.

Turn time into an ally, not an enemy

Small habits are powerful because their benefits compound over the long term. The more time I practice an small healthy habit the bigger reward I will get in the future.

On the opposite side, the longer I keep a bad habit, the more difficult it will be to quit this bad habit and the more damages it will generate on me.

In other words, every day is either an investment or a debt

It's for you and them

Imagine that it is the first day of a new year. I am with my friends, and I decide to start a swimming routine at the local pool.

One of my friends says, "That's an amazing idea. Let's do it together."

And it works. Every Tuesday after work, even when I feel tired, I go swimming with my friend. However, whenever my friend messages me to say that he is too busy to go to the pool, I suddenly feel exhausted as well, and I do not go either.

Here is the explanation: if someone relies on me to exercise with them, I am always there. If I make a promise to someone, I keep it. But I struggle to keep promises made to myself. In other words, I am able to respect others much more than I respect myself.

So, if I want to build lasting habits, I know that I must consider a commitment to myself to be just as important as a promise made to a friend.

I must never forget that I train my brain, my mindset, and my body for my future self.

But even if I decide that my life is not worth such efforts, I still think that my inaction would have a severe impact on the people around me.

If I become unable to complete basic administrative tasks, if I remain permanently pessimistic about life, or if I cannot even go to the grocery store on my own, I lose my autonomy. As a result, I create additional work and concern for the people who help me.

Who are those people? Caregivers, neighbours, children, and relatives.

My choices are connected to other people's lives.

So, if I do not want to take care of myself for my own sake, then I should do it to protect others.

What a wonderful purpose.

CHAPTER SEVEN

WHICH HABITS FIT (ME/YOU) BEST?

So far we have seen that starting healthy habits is hard, but yet, we know more about the science of habits and we have learned several tactics to start and last. We even reflect on why we do that.

We should think: *It's now time to learn what really good habits are, choose three of them and finally start building them.*

Nevertheless, this book will present a collection of habit only in its third part.

Here is why:

The number of habits that are potentially beneficial for the human brain, mindset and body is enormous -so enormous that we cannot adopt all of them. Moreover, many of these habits may not suit everyone or may require significant strategy and effort to develop (see Chapter five).

If somebody desperately tries to adopt a habit they do not genuinely enjoy, this may become dangerous. If they fail to build this habit because it doesn't fit their lifestyle, they may start to see themselves as incapable, and in the long run their psychological well-being could deteriorate. We can all agree that this would be the exact opposite of this book purpose.

Therefore, before starting to build a habit, we need to take time to determine which habits are truly suited to each of us.

And if someone realise after one month that a habit is not made for them, they should not insist but instead take time again to reflect on which habit would suit them better. Once again, this proves, that the earlier we start, the better it is, because we then have enough time to try, stop, reflect and change direction: what a relief not to feel rushed!

Indeed, in order to make the best choice of habits, we must distinguish between what we consume for our body, brain and mindset and what we actively build through our actions.

Let us take a few examples from each of the core pillars of the healthy longevity:

Cognitive habits

What we consume	Computing capacity and memory killer (By using AI)	Chronic stress and high cortisol levels (By over-working)	Focusing capacity killer (By over-scrolling on social media)
What we build	Computing capacity (By practicing mental arithmetic)	Memory capacity (by learning by heart)	Focus capacity (By reading complex texts)

Psychological habits

What we consume	Negative mindset (By over watching the news)	Procrastination (By consuming passive entertainment)	Creativity killer (By over-using AI)
What we build	Confidence (by positive self-talk)	Positive mindset (by writing a gratitude journal)	Creativity (by creating intentional human connections)

Physical habits

What we consume	Cardio vascular disease (By eat ultra-processed food)	Heart attack (by smoking tobacco)	Back pain, reduced mobility, joint stiffness, muscle loss (by having a sedentary lifestyle)
What we build	Stressless (by doing breathing exercises)	Strong heart (by having a frequent cardio activity)	Strong body (by working out)

Indeed, the first thing to do is to know who we are in terms of habits. We need to visualise our personal habit map. What we currently do and don't.

Then we could choose our new first habits among cognitive, psychological and physical ones. We also could choose between something we import and something we build.

For example, stop smoking is a hard challenge for a lot of people. Don't try to change this habit right now could be a good option for them. Instead, they could choose an easier one.

In other words, we need to be honest about all the habits we have to give up and all the ones we have to build, but we have to keep in mind that starting small is key.

So to pick up an habit that fit me, I asked myself three questions:

- is this habit is easy to build/give up?
- Is this habit attractive by itself (I don't need to make it attractive)
- do I have enough time to set it up every day?

If the new habit checks this all three boxes, it's certainly fit very well to me.

CHAPTER HEIGHT

HOW TO BUILD A REAL-LIFE-PROVEN
SCHEDULE?

Before to answer this chapter's question, let's talk again about habits.

What is the good time frequency for an habit?

If I do a sport exercise every Saturday, is it an habit?

The formal answer is yes. It will be the same if I go the cinema every month and if I go the ski resort every year.

All are habits, but an habit that I practice very often tells who I am. If I run every day or twice a week, I am a runner, but if I only run during my summer holidays week, I am only someone who have some running session on holidays, I am not a runner.

Habits are great when they compound and to compound efficacy they need a high time frequency. The more frequent I practice an habit, the more benefits it gives me.

So, when we talk about life-proven-schedule, we talk about a schedule that includes daily habits.

That said, most of the time we know what we have to do to improve our overall health, but we don't do it because we haven't enough free time.

Daily emergencies always win and our schedules are completely packed. In such a context, if we add three new habits related to physical, cognitive and psychological activities, we may become overwhelmed. Once again, we agree that it is not this book's purpose.

We need a realistic schedule that includes healthy habits and fit our busy lives.

So before thinking about new habits, let's look for making room in our daily agenda. It's a big deal, it might takes a while, but is it possible.

First, we need to audit our schedule by tracking all our activities in a day during one week. When they are all listed, we sorted them by importance. To know if an activity is important, I ask myself 'what will be the long term consequence if I give up that activity right now?'. The more painful the consequence is, the most important the activity is.

Then we study the quater less important activities. In that group we could give up some and make room in our schedule. For each activity of that group, I asked myself 'Is that activity important for my long term overall health?'. If the answer is 'yes', I turn this activity into a truly daily habit. And if the answer is 'not', I should give it up, indeed I will make room for new habits.

Now we know how to make a real-life-proven schedule with healthy habits.

Of course schedules are different from a people to another, but they also different in time for a same person.

That is a very important point: priorities in life are different regarding to the ages.

So, this is how, generally speaking, we can integrate healthy habits in a real-life schedule considering our age.

Around 25, just after education having a job is the priority. We spent a lot of time for job-applying and when we are hired we need time to truly understand our new mission. Free time remains for a 15 minutes to 30 minutes per day dedicated to healthy habits.

After 35, building a family is the priority. We are looking for a life partner, we have our first children. Young children require lot of time and we need to find a house and maintain it. And of course working time still takes room in the schedule. Free time is rare, so we should keep a 15-minute session for practising three healthy habits per day.

After 45, job comes back in priority, we want to be promoted before becoming too old. Children are more independent but we need to finance their studies. So we can spend more time building good habits each day, between 30 minutes until an hour.

After 55, at work we need to be competitive compared to young workers this requires focus, energy and creativity, but no additional time. Moreover the children are now independent, so we can dedicate an hour per day to strengthen our healthy longevity.

And over 65, it's retirement. Indeed we should spend at least two hours per day for our sovereign longevity.

CHAPTER NINE

HOW TO STAY MOTIVATED?

Congratulations you have made a good start!

You know that the power of habit is in repetition and that benefits from habits compounded in the time. But life is full of surprises and a good start in setting habits never guaranty an endless situation.

Three main dangers threat your habits structure: the boring zone, the too-easy zone and the too-hard zone.

The boring zone.

If you're loosing motivation for an habit it's might be because you think the habit became boring. At the beginning it was fun to do it because it was new, but now you are not excited anymore.

First think that felling a boring task often depends of the context. How exciting/boring was the task before and what about the next task just after?

For example, if you're a watching social media before and you have plan to do a memorisation exercise, the exercise will always feel difficult because social media are made to bring lot of dopamine without effort. You can fight against

a product designed by the best addictive specialists in the world.

So a very good tactic is to do very boring things before and after that memorisation exercise, it will immediately become captivating.

Finally, if that tip doesn't work, it might mean it is really too boring for you, so you can change your goal and try to set up a new habit.

The too-easy-zone.

If things are too easy, you can lose your motivation to do them. You might face this issue quickly because, one of the most important steps in setting up new habits is to make them easy.

To know if a task has turned from easy to too easy, you can evaluate your attention level when you are doing it.

If you are able to perfectly complete the task, although your mind is focusing on anything but what you're doing. That's a sign, it's time to choose a harder task or a new habit.

Let's take an example: you are setting up a cognitive strengthening routine by doing a fifteen-minutes exercise. If you can perfectly find and install the right pieces of the puzzle while you are thinking about your shopping list for the dinner: your exercise is too easy!

The too-hard-zone.

It's either the frustrating zone or the painful zone. Imagine that you want to strengthen your cognition with a daily fifteen-minute mathematics exercise. If you're 45 and if the last time you heard about mathematics was in college, trying to solve the same problems than in your last college year will certainly stuck you for a very long time and you will be frustrated. Even worse you might loose your energy and consider badly yourself.

Nevertheless try-error process is also a good way to strengthen your cognition, so don't qualify too early an habit as too difficult. But if you can complete an exercise in five sessions, it's time to choose an easier one.

One of my favorite habit rule: '80/20/0'

'80/20/0' as eighty percent easy, twenty percent effort and zero percent suffering. With this rule, try to fell if your habit is mainly easy to keep your self-confidence, a little

demanding to keep excitement and never suffering to avoid despondency or injury in case of physical exercise.

CHAPTER TEN

A PLAN B IS ALWAYS POSSIBLE

Because habits are essential for your sovereign longevity, we talk a lot about how to create good habits in this manifesto's part two, but in practice it is a big deal. What to do if you can't stick goods habits?

This manifesto tries to give you some quick recipes to start easily to built lasting habits, nevertheless it is not a book about the science of habits.

Do you know for example that some researchers think that your environment is more influent that you willpower to set a new habit?

The science of habit is something amazing and really effective, so if you struggle to build your ageing well habit dedicated books are your B plan. To my mind a really appreciate 'Atomic habits' from James Clear, but there many others. Forget your healthy longevity goals for a while and become a specialist of habits.

Recoding the problem:

- > science fix the wrong problem: longevity only
- > individual issue turn into social issue -social decline
- > policy can't fix the problem

Recoding the solution:

- > Turning lifespan into healthspan: set a the 85FF goal
- > Turning policy into personal action: set the 3F habits
- > The life-proven-schedule

Recoding the habits

- > Turning boring advice into thrilling recipes

GAME PAUSE ANSWERS

#1

GANDHI → 78 years → active until assassinated

SOCRATES → 70 years → sharp until the hemlock

MARIE CURIE → 66 years → radiation ended her life early 💔

#2

Michael Phelps → 23 Olympic golds → severe depression

Simone Biles → greatest gymnast ever → mental health crisis

Naomi Osaka → world tennis champion → anxiety and depression

Marcus Rashford → elite footballer → mental health struggles

Most people say « I want to live a long life, but I don't want to be in poor health and dependent - yet right now, I have no time to prepare for my future health.

Do you feel the problem coming?

By 2050, one in four people on earth will be over 60 - without dramatic health improvements for the over 60s younger generations will pay an unsustainable price.

The price for younger generations? Lower income. Lower living conditions. Poorer health.

So if people care about their parents, their children and their own future - they must embrace the ageing issue.

This book's purpose is to age well and help others do the same.

That said, that's where the problems start.

Ageing well is a very complex challenge at the crossroads of virtually every academic discipline: genetics, biology, physiology, nutrition, psychology, neurology, physics, economics, sociology and even theology and philosophy.

Fascinating - but quickly overwhelming, since nobody can master all the disciplines at once. So let's try to keep things simple and make it fun!